

Grouping notes

The way a rhythm is written should reflect the meter, making the beat structure clear and easy to read. The arrangement of rests, beams, and ties all contribute to the clear notation of rhythms.

SEE ALSO

◀ 24–25 Beats and measures

◀ 28–29 Beams and dots

◀ 30–31 Time signatures

◀ 32–33 Compound time

Showing the beat

Generally, notes and rests are grouped to show the separate beats. This depends first on the time signature, and then on the details of the note values within each measure. It should be so clear that the performer doesn't notice how it is done.

Two separate eighth note rests, rather than one quarter note rest

Separate beams for beats 1 and 2

2/4

1 2 1 2 1 2

◀ Rhythms in 2/4 time

Rests and beams are written in this example so that the second beat of each measure is always clear.

A tie joins two notes across the bar line

3/4

1 2 3 1 2 3 1 2 3 1 2 3

◀ Rhythms in 3/4 time

The two quarter note rests in the last measure show the beat more clearly than a single half note rest would.

Beaming across the beat

In 2/4 time, four even eighth notes can be beamed across the beat, or six eighth notes in 3/4 time. If the rhythms become more complicated, it is best to separate the beats. Dotted rhythm pairs—a dotted eighth note followed by a sixteenth note—stand out clearly if beamed separately.

2/4

◀ 2/4 time

In the second measure, the eighth notes are even and can be beamed together.

3/4

◀ 3/4 time

In this example, with its regular rhythm, the eighth notes can be beamed together.

Dotted rhythm pairs

3/4

◀ 3/4 time

Here, the rhythms are more complicated. It is clearer if the beats are shown separately.